NEWS RELEASE

High School Swimming & Diving Rules Changes Address Number of Dives During Championship Meets

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE Contact: Sandy Searcy

INDIANAPOLIS, IN (July 13, 2026) — Starting with the 2026–27 swimming and diving season, state high school associations will have the option to change the number of dives performed by participants during a championship meet.

This change highlights five rules proposals brought forth by the NFHS Swimming and Diving Rules Committee during its annual meeting, held March 22–24 in downtown Indianapolis. The NFHS Board of Directors subsequently approved all submitted rule changes.

Rule 9-4-2h (Choice of Dives) now states that "by state association adoption, the number of qualifiers advancing to the semifinal round may be increased." An additional note states, "by state association adoption, states may alter the number of dives for their state championship series of meets."

In its rationale, the committee pointed out that participation in high school diving continues to decline in many states, and reducing the number of dives could expand opportunities for student-athletes to participate in the event.

"The committee noted that the exception within the note is tightly crafted and limited to state association championship competition," said Sandy Searcy, NFHS director of sports and liaison to the Swimming and Diving Rules Committee. "Allowing championship meet modification is consistent with other provisions in Rule 5-1-1 that allow states to address issues such as scheduling and affect only their own competitions, similar to deciding whether to contest events in other sports."

Additional approved changes were made to rules regarding uniforms, electronic devices, and the form of individual events.

Under Rule 3-3-4b(2), wording was added to clarify that bonded or taped seams on suits are not subject to permeability requirements. This change mirrors standards established by World Aquatics.

Rules 3-5-1 and 3-5-2 were also updated to state that no competitor shall wear any audio (microphone) or video (camera) device during a race or dive.

Mirroring language was added to rules governing the butterfly (Rule 8-2-3g) and freestyle (Rule 8-2-4e), stating: "Once some part of the swimmer's head has passed the 5-yard/5-meter mark immediately prior to reaching for the finish, the swimmer may be completely submerged." The changes align with national trends in the sport.

"Sandy Searcy's leadership is greatly appreciated as is her passion for swimming and diving, and the same can be said for every member of the NFHS Swimming & Diving Rules Committee," said Rod Garman, chair of the Swimming and Diving Rules Committee and assistant executive director of the Kansas State High School Activities Association. "So much knowledge and expertise are evident during committee discussions of rules proposals and each member's contributions are valued. The listening and respect for one another is paramount when making such important decisions that impact education-based swimming and diving across the country."

A complete listing of the swimming and diving rules changes will be available on the NFHS website at www.nfhs.org. Click on "Activities & Sports" at the top of the home page and select "Swimming and Diving." The print version of the 2026-27 Swimming & Diving Rules Book will be available for purchase in late May at www.NFHS.com, and the digital version will be available via NFHS Digital at www.NFHS.org.

According to the 2024-25 NFHS High School Athletics Participation Survey, swimming and diving is the 10th-most popular sport for boys with 119,102 participants in 8,105 schools, and the ninth-most popular sport for girls with 138,303 participants in 8,465 schools.

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About the National Federation of State High School Associations (NFHS)

The NFHS, based in Indianapolis, Indiana, is the national leadership organization for high school sports and performing arts activities. Since 1920, the NFHS has led the development of education-based interscholastic sports and performing arts activities that help students succeed in their lives. The NFHS sets direction for the future by building awareness and support, improving the participation experience, establishing consistent standards and rules for competition, and helping those who oversee high school sports and activities. The NFHS writes playing rules for 18 sports for boys and girls at the high school level. Through its 50 member state associations and the District of Columbia, the NFHS reaches more than 19,800 high schools and 12 million participants in high school activity programs, including more than 8.2 million in high school sports. As the recognized national authority on interscholastic activity programs, the NFHS conducts national meetings; sanctions interstate events; offers online publications and services for high school coaches and officials; sponsors professional organizations for high school coaches, officials, speech and debate coaches, and music adjudicators; serves as the national source for interscholastic coach training; and serves as a national information resource of interscholastic athletics and activities. For more information, visit the NFHS website at www.nfhs.org.

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